

THE EPIDEMIC OF FATHERLESSNESS

Implications for Ethical Development
and Mental Health

Qualitative Phenomenological Study by:

James Ellis, Jr.

Liberty University

A Dissertation Presented in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements for the Degree
Doctor of Philosophy School of Health Sciences Liberty University, Lynchburg,
VA 2025

TABLE OF CONTENTS

ABSTRACT	3
CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION	4
Overview.....	4
Background	5
Situation of Self	18
Problem Statement	19
Purpose Statement.....	21
Significance of this Study	22
Research Questions	23
Summary	25

ABSTRACT

The purpose of this phenomenological study was to explore the negative effects of fatherlessness on childhood development and the long-term impact on adult mental health. According to Bhugra, Watson, and Wijesuriya (2021), significant racial demographic differences existed in the prevalence of fatherless households. Harris (2019) noted that mental illness affected individuals across various racial groups, including Whites, Blacks, Hispanics, Asians, and Native Americans. Research by Bhugra et al. (2021) indicated that children raised in homes without fathers were more likely to experience mental health challenges.

This study sought to determine whether a fatherless environment predisposed children to the development of skewed worldviews, aberrant behavior, and/or mental illness and unethical behavior in adulthood. Fifteen individuals were surveyed, interviewed, and asked to complete questionnaires. The participants, recruited from a church community in Houston, Texas, engaged in interviews conducted both in person and via Zoom conferencing. A structured methodology was followed to ensure consistency in data collection.

The findings revealed emotional and psychological impacts associated with growing up without a father. Literature suggested that the number of children living in fatherless homes represented a rapidly growing segment of society (Folk, Stuewig, Mashek, Tangney, & Grossmann, 2019). This study was grounded in Family Systems Theory and Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, examining how disparities in fatherless homes affected mental health and child development across different racial groups.

Keywords: mental health, ethnic groups, fatherlessness, Family Systems Theory, Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory

CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION

Overview

- Growing up in a single-parent household can result in significant mental and developmental challenges for children (Norton, 2021).
- Research indicates that, compared to children raised in two-parent households, those in single-parent homes, particularly those led by mothers, exhibit higher rates of mental health issues and suboptimal developmental outcomes (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020).
- Since the 1960s, the prevalence of fatherless families has risen across all five major racial groups in the United States: Black, White, Hispanic, Native American, and Asian (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020; Misra et al., 2021; DeGarmo & Jones, 2019).
- Mental health conditions such as depression, anxiety, attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD), bipolar disorder, and schizophrenia are often influenced by environmental factors and family structure during childhood (Tanhan, 2019).

Background

Although recent research highlights some progress, Black and Hispanic children continue to experience disproportionately higher rates of mental illness and poorer developmental outcomes compared to Native American, Asian, and White children (Kelly & Coughlan, 2019).

To address these disparities, the application of Family Systems Theory and Ecological Systems Theory has been strongly advocated.

Parenting, inherently complex, becomes even more challenging when mental illness is present within the family unit. The contemporary focus on mood disorders and childhood development underscores the importance of these issues in today's society.

Historical Context

1. Early Studies

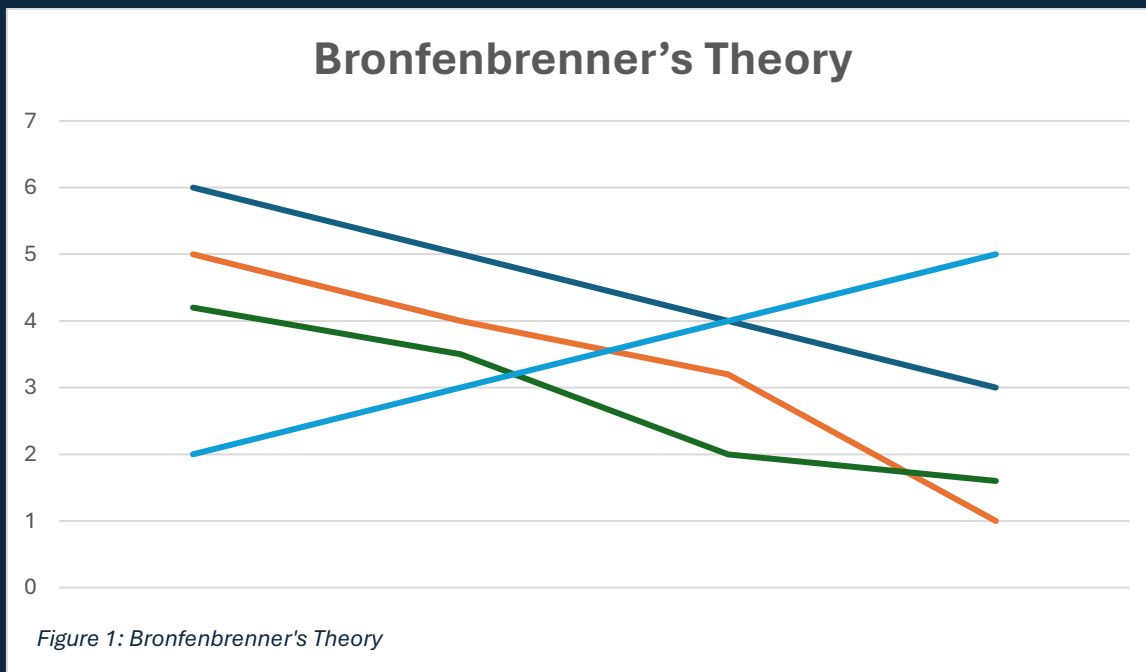
Early studies identified a correlation between single-parent households and increased prevalence of mental and behavioral problems in children. However, the urgency and resources necessary to address these challenges were frequently overlooked in key environments such as:

- Homes
- Schools
- Community centers (Lu et al., 2019).

For example, research indicates that children aged 10 to 15 exhibit high rates of ADHD, depression, and anxiety, yet families often fail to seek necessary interventions due to a lack of understanding (Uddin et al., 2020). In certain cases, a child may develop classroom-related anxiety after witnessing repeated verbal abuse toward their mother by their father (Tudge et al., 2021).

2. Bronfenbrenner's Theory

Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory elucidates how negative environmental behaviors can have long-lasting adverse effects on a child's developmental trajectory (Tanhan, 2019). Additionally, more recent studies reveal that ongoing childhood trauma may contribute to psychological conditions such as learned helplessness (Yoshikawa et al., 2020) [Figure 1].



Mental illness prevalence is notably higher among children growing up in fatherless homes (Norton, 2021). According to Holmes et al. (2020), mental health conditions such as depression, anxiety, bipolar disorder, and ADHD are increasingly common among children raised in single-parent households.

These mental health difficulties are frequently rooted in cultural factors and are intricately connected to the structure of family values (Adan et al., 2019). Furthermore, Ramatsetse and Ross (2022) underscore the complexities involved in diagnosing mental illnesses such as depression, noting that symptom presentation often overlaps across different racial groups, leading to potential misdiagnoses.

Prior studies suggest that approximately 25 percent of individuals with mental illnesses believe they can manage their condition independently or with the support of loved ones, rather than seeking professional help (Kelly & Coughlan, 2019) [Figure 2].

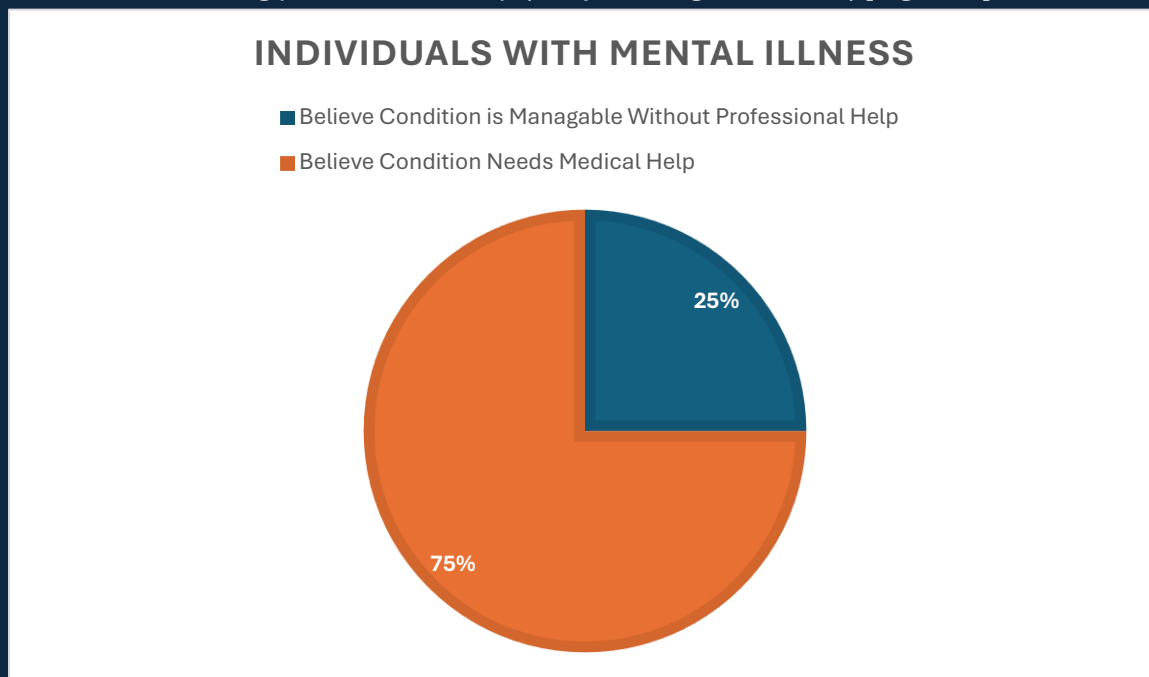


Figure 2: Kelly & Coughlan Study

Research employing modeling techniques has identified a strong association between the proportion of children living in single-parent households and the prevalence of mental health conditions such as depression, anxiety, low self-esteem, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), and bipolar disorder (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020).

3. Importance of Recognition

Amen (2020) emphasized the importance of early recognition and intervention, noting that timely treatment can significantly reduce the prevalence and severity of these mental health conditions.

Duckworth (2020) further found that while a father figure during early childhood is critical, the complete absence of a father is more strongly associated with the development of mental health issues such as depression and anxiety.

The stressors of financial constraints, educational challenges, health concerns, and exposure to violence exert significant influence on the mental and behavioral development of children within families (Agochukwu & Wittmann, 2019).

4. Mental Health Over Time

Although children may not encounter these stressors simultaneously or immediately, their cumulative effects can profoundly impact mental health over time. As Harris (2019) notes, such stressors can even alter brain development, affecting key functions such as language acquisition, learning capacity, and cognitive abilities. Torrey (2020) compares mental illness to the struggle of differentiating between reality and perception, where the distinction between the two is often ambiguous.

Research indicates that mental illness can disrupt cognitive processes, creating a complex mental landscape that impedes clear thinking. Childhood development, particularly when influenced by adverse experiences, is further compromised when children are encouraged to suppress their thoughts and emotions (Weber, 2020).

Moreover, Agochukwu and Wittmann (2019) highlight how depression within families can deplete the energy and motivation required for daily functioning. Recent data from Duckworth (2020) underscores this trend, revealing an 8.9 percent increase in depression rates among children aged 3 to 17 since 2019.

5. Current Understanding

The understanding of mental health and developmental disorders has evolved significantly, driven by ongoing research and heightened societal awareness (Tian & Wang, 2019). Despite these advancements, mental health conditions have worsened due to the persistent lack of adequate services and the societal stigma surrounding mental illness (Abdisa et al., 2020).

The National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) emphasizes that a diagnosis alone is insufficient for effective treatment, urging consideration of factors such as disability and the duration of symptoms.

The fifth edition of the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5) remains a critical resource for mental health professionals in diagnosing a broad spectrum of mental disorders. However, in the 1970s, clinicians recognized only a limited range of disorders, such as depression, anxiety, bipolar disorder, and PTSD, based on narrower diagnostic criteria (Rodriguez-Villa et al., 2020).

Social Context

1. Extent of Study

This qualitative study explores the potential linkage between fatherlessness and the development of mental illnesses, as well as whether personal resilience alone can mitigate the psychological effects associated with an absent father. Specifically, the study examines the higher incidence of mental health conditions, such as depression, bipolar disorder, and anxiety, among children raised by single mothers who serve as sole providers. Research suggests that children in single-parent households frequently experience feelings of being unloved (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020).

This study also explores how family system frameworks offer alternative perspectives on what constitutes beneficial versus harmful parental actions. According to Harris (2019), the presence of paternal leadership is crucial in reducing the stigma surrounding mental illness, as a father's physical presence fosters psychological accountability in children. Bhugra, Watson, and Wijesuriya (2021) note that while mental illness is prevalent across all racial groups, the manifestation of symptoms can differ significantly based on cultural contexts.

2. Study Approach

This study employs a phenomenological approach to investigate the various causes of fatherlessness, including death, divorce, and incarceration. Harris (2019) argues that societal pressures often drive fathers into difficult circumstances, contributing to their absence.

Fatherlessness is frequently linked to adverse outcomes such as unemployment, poverty, incarceration, teenage pregnancy, violence, and substance abuse (Tian & Wang, 2019) [Figure 3]. Society remains challenged by the question of how and why so many children grow up without a father figure. Faced with social and economic pressures, some men may resort to illegal activities, which often lead to incarceration.

Strong family structures are considered stabilizing forces in society. For example, Brewer (2023) found that in a study of 56 school shootings, only 18 percent of the perpetrators had been raised by both biological parents, whereas 82 percent had grown up in unstable environments or were orphaned [Figure 4].



Figure 3: Links to Fatherlessness

FATHERLESSNESS AND SCHOOL SHOOTINGS

■ Shooters Raised by Both Parents ■ Shooters Raised in Unstable Environments or Orphaned

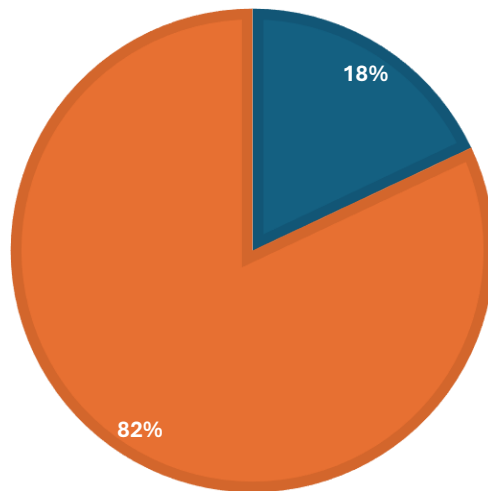


Figure 5: Fatherlessness and School Shootings

The difficulties children encounter in such settings often persist into adulthood, further impeding their ability to adapt and thrive (Marco-Gracia, 2021). This research highlights the complex social issues faced by children from fatherless households, emphasizing the need to understand these challenges across diverse racial groups in the United States.

A sociological perspective is vital, as it helps frame key questions, identifies structural factors, and guides the development of strategies to address the difficulties associated with fatherlessness (Blacksher & Valles, 2021).

Currently, approximately 15.5 million children in the U.S. live in households without a father figure, compared to 7.7 million in 1968 (Hermez & Washington, 2021). The number of children living solely with their mothers has doubled over the past 50 years (Bekdash, 2021).

3. Goal of Study

Regardless of the specific findings from this phenomenological study, sociological analysis offers an empathetic framework for understanding how fatherlessness can hinder children's potential for personal growth and development.

Research that illuminates these dynamics is critical for promoting a more inclusive society that values integrity in fathers. Fathers' contributions often embody integrity, compassion, and humility, providing children with emotional stability and love (DeGarmo & Jones, 2019). The shortage of psychologists, psychiatrists, and behavioral therapists, combined with the rising number of divorced and single-parent households in America, exacerbates these social issues (Misra et al., 2021). For example, the divorce rate in Texas among Black couples is 12.7 percent, compared to 10.8 percent among White couples (Ishizuka, 2019) [Figure 5].

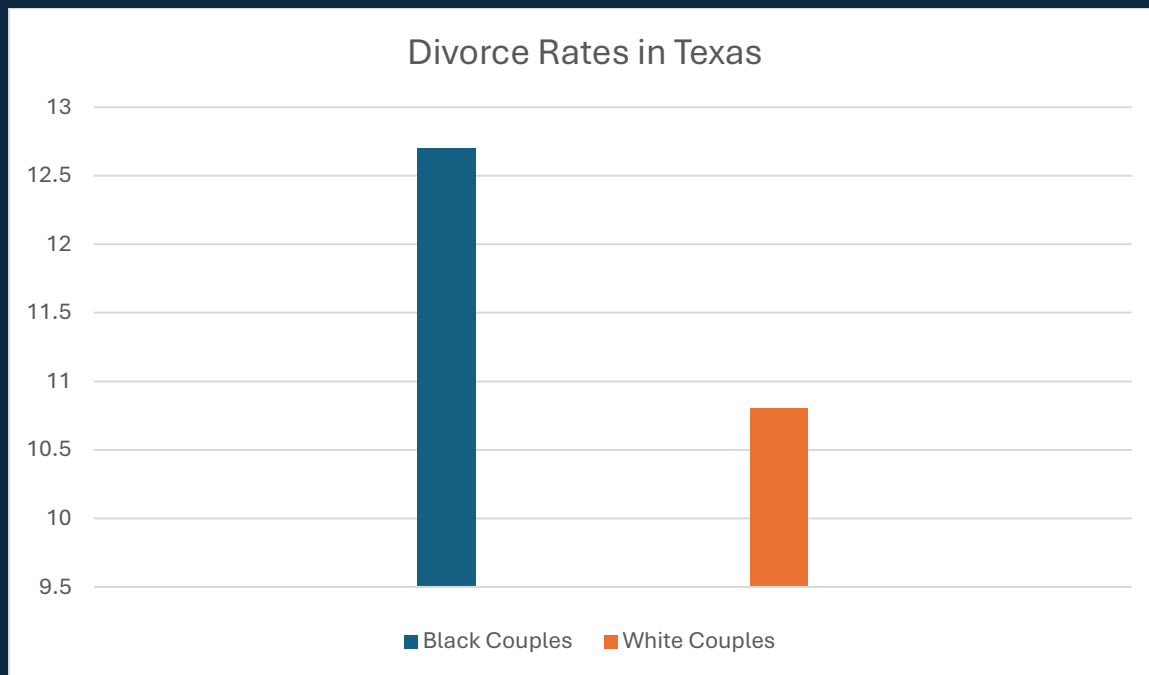


Figure 6: Divorce Rates in Texas

Children from divorced families frequently encounter social and health challenges, including emotional distress, anxiety, and depression, which can persist into adulthood if left unaddressed (Makwana, 2019).

The disruption of family structure may limit children's access to consistent emotional support, increase financial stress within the household, and reduce access to mental health services, exacerbating their vulnerability to psychological difficulties.

Many individuals in need of mental health services today do not receive adequate care due to various barriers, such as socioeconomic status and access to resources (Lu, 2019). Furthermore, stigmatizing attitudes toward mental illness are often reinforced by the absence of a principled father figure (Tau, 2020).

According to the U.S. Census Bureau, 48 percent of Black children live only with their mothers, and 72 percent of the U.S. population recognizes fatherlessness as a significant societal concern (DeLuca et al., 2021).

The presence of a father is essential in helping children focus on solutions rather than fixating on problems, fostering resilience in the face of mental health challenges (Winnicott, 2019). This perspective underscores the importance of transforming adversity into opportunities for personal growth and development.

Theoretical Context

1. Frameworks

Theoretical frameworks, such as Bowen's Family Systems Theory and Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory, offer valuable insights into how environmental factors shape mental behavior and development across different racial groups. For example, the mental health disparity among Black males is often linked to a perceived disconnection from reality, which can be rooted in the absence of paternal figures and stable family structures (Taylor et al., 2020).

Cultural influences also play a significant role in mental health and resilience, although the lived experiences of Black individuals in America present a complex and multifaceted picture (De La Houssaye, 2022).

Both Bronfenbrenner's and Bowen's theories highlight the layered and interdependent nature of environmental influences on childhood development, guiding an understanding of how social and familial environments impact mental health outcomes. According to these frameworks, a father's role is one of guidance and responsibility, serving as a stabilizing figure in the child's developmental ecosystem (Grau et al., 2022).

2. Purpose of Study

The purpose of this phenomenological study was to explore how the absence of a father in the household affects mental health and childhood development. This research design is particularly suited to the study's objectives, as it enables a comprehensive examination of the lived experiences of fatherless children as they navigate mental health challenges.

By exploring these life experiences, the study empowers individuals to accept mental challenges and leverage them as opportunities for personal growth. Ultimately, this research provided critical knowledge, confidence, and awareness to those struggling with or supporting individuals with mental illness.

Stigma surrounding mental illness frequently labels individuals as dangerous, irrational, or incompetent (Uddin et al., 2020). For the purposes of this research, mental illness is defined as encompassing a broad range of emotional and personality disorders, which are diagnosed by mental health professionals using the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5) through comprehensive screening processes.

3. Guiding Framework

The primary guiding frameworks for this study—Family Systems Theory and Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory—emphasize the significant role that human

behavior and family dynamics play in shaping mental health outcomes. Family Systems Theory posits that family interactions have a profound influence on individual behaviors, highlighting a bidirectional relationship between parent and child, where family dynamics often exacerbate communication issues (Weber, 2019). Bowen's Family Systems Theory further underscores how negative familial interactions can lead to predictable patterns of behavior in children (Jakimowicz, Perry, & Lewis, 2020).

To promote a positive home environment, the theory advocates for effective communication and active listening within families. In contrast, Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory emphasizes the role of a child's biological environment as the primary influence on their development throughout life (Tudge, Navarro, Merçon-Vargas, & Payir, 2021).

This theory comprises five interrelated systems that together shape the individual's development. They are as follows:

- Microsystems
- Macrosystems
- Chronosystems
- Exosystems
- Mesosystems

The goal of this research is to integrate these two theoretical frameworks in order to establish a foundation for interventions that support mental wellness.

4. Other Concerns

Previous studies have demonstrated that mental health professionals often misdiagnose individuals from different racial groups due to distinct symptom presentations across Blacks, Whites, Hispanics, Asians, and Native Americans (Bhugra et al., 2021). For instance, Black men are frequently misdiagnosed with more severe or less treatable psychiatric disorders, as their emotions are often misinterpreted as psychotic (Ayano et al., 2021; Harris, 2019). Commonly misdiagnosed conditions include schizoaffective disorder, major depressive disorder, schizophrenia, and bipolar disorder (Ayano et al., 2021).

Weber (2020) highlights the disproportionate number of Black children under the age of 18 living in single-parent households, a disparity that underscores significant racial differences in family structure. For example, while 75 percent of White children under 18 reside with both parents, only 40 percent of Black children share this experience.

This study aims to examine how resources can be utilized to mitigate and prevent mental health issues by exploring the lived experiences of individuals facing challenges within these family dynamics.

5. Other Factors

By analyzing these life experiences, this phenomenological study seeks to offer support through shared coping strategies and insights into managing mental health challenges. The concept of "latchkey kids"—children left unsupervised for extended periods—is particularly prevalent in fatherless homes and unstructured families, presenting a unique set of challenges (Rousseau & Frounfelker, 2019).

Blacksher and Valles (2021) define latchkey kids as those who frequently lack parental supervision. Research indicates that growing up in such environments can negatively impact human development, contributing to emotional instability and creating a disadvantageous context for mental health (Abdisa et al., 2020).

Although latchkey children are more common in White families than in other racial groups (Abdisa et al., 2020), all children in these situations often face heightened stress without the guidance and presence of a father figure. In contrast, nuclear families, which consist of two parents, offer a different dynamic in child development (Grau et al., 2022). According to data from the 2020 U.S. Census, 80 percent of single-parent households are headed by single mothers, a proportion that has been steadily increasing since the late 20th century (Marco-Gracia, 2021).

6. Basis of Paper

The literature suggests that growing up in a fatherless household is strongly associated with negative outcomes in terms of well-being and increased adversity in life (Lange et al., 2021). Harris (2019) further notes that the absence of a father, coupled with society's many stressors, can adversely affect children's cognitive processes, ultimately leading to mental health challenges. As a result, the lack of a paternal figure can contribute to a range of issues, including depression, substance abuse, anxiety, psychological disturbances, violent behavior, and early sexual activity (Lange et al., 2021).

The role of a father is thus critical in shaping a child's sense of purpose and influencing their career planning and future aspirations (Ishizuka, 2019). Research also highlights significant variations in the percentage of fatherless children across different ethnic groups (Taylor et al., 2020). For instance, 57.6 percent of Black children grow up without a father, compared to 31.2 percent of Hispanic children, 20.7 percent of White children, 16 percent of Asian children, and 29 percent of Native American children (DeMartini et al., 2022).

To address the mental health and developmental challenges faced by children in these environments, this study applied both Bowen's Family Systems Theory and Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory. Bronfenbrenner's theory conceptualizes a child's environment as a system of interconnected influences, and this study will explore how disconnection within the family impacts children's mental health and development. Moitra et al. (2022) assert that disparities in mental health outcomes among racial groups are exacerbated by a lack of access to adequate resources and treatment, despite the fact that environmental stressors are often similar across races.

The absence of directional guidance and a sense of urgency within the family unit is a key factor that contributes to differences in how various racial groups cope with mental health issues such as depression, anxiety, and ADHD. It is imperative not only to minimize these gaps but also to uncover their root causes by building on future research and evidence. Existing literature suggests that children are subjected to significant stress, especially during traumatic events such as the COVID-19 pandemic (Abdisa et al., 2020).

The pandemic caused widespread parental unemployment, increased poverty, academic learning loss, and forced early employment among youth, in addition to the loss of parents or caregivers for many children. These factors have left millions of Americans grappling with financial instability and mental health challenges (Golberstein et al., 2020).

Situation of Self

1. Personal Connection

My personal commitment to mental health advocacy deepened after witnessing the impact of mental illness on my sister's life. Her experience, coupled with my work at the National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI), has inspired my exploration of fatherlessness as a factor influencing mental health outcomes.

As a mental health advocate and employee of the National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI), I have directly observed the pain and suffering endured by families as they navigate the complexities of mental health concerns.

2. My Experience

My experiences speaking at health fairs have shed light on the pervasive stigma surrounding mental illness, with many individuals expressing frustration over the perceived lack of urgency and concern in seeking appropriate help for mental disorders.

Bridging the gap between societal stigma and embracing mental health challenges as opportunities for personal growth has been a central focus of my advocacy.

My commitment to reducing the stigma associated with mental and behavioral health issues was solidified after a personal tragedy—my sister's attack by an individual suffering from mental illness.

This event deepened my resolve to raise awareness about mental health and to understand the factors contributing to the prevalence of fatherlessness in society. My pursuit of this understanding has been furthered by extensive research on how various racial and ethnic groups respond to mental illness, fueling my drive to explore the barriers that lead to fatherlessness.

This research is directly inspired by both my sister's experience and my observations regarding the growing incidence of fatherless households in modern society.

Problem Statement

1. In Brief

This study explored the experiences of families without a paternal figure, focusing on how the absence of a father influences childhood development and its impact on mental health outcomes into adulthood.

Scholarly research has shed light on several causes of father absence, including incarceration and divorce, and their resulting impact on families.

The literature highlights a notable gap in services for children from non-traditional households who develop early-onset mental disorders and behavioral challenges.

2. The Study

Given that mental illnesses often manifest before the age of 25, with symptoms typically emerging in childhood or adolescence, incorporating mental health resources into the support structures for these families is essential (Duckworth, 2022).

This study will specifically examine how stressful family environments contribute to the development of mental health conditions such as anxiety, depression, and ADHD. Liu et al. (2019) emphasize that the absence of parental support, compounded by a hostile environment and financial stress, can result in a dissatisfying life for children.

3. The Research

Research shows that all racial and ethnic groups are susceptible to making poor decisions in response to hostile environments (Nazroo et al., 2019). Blacks and Hispanics, in particular, are more likely to view mild depression as abnormal or indicative of weakness, perpetuating stigma (Moitra et al., 2022). Additionally, studies demonstrate that the father's absence diminishes children's motivation to take responsibility for their behavior, which further erodes their sense of self-efficacy and structure (Tian & Wang, 2019).

Among Native Americans, depression and anxiety are often managed through spiritual guidance or healers rather than through professional mental health services (Blackmore et al., 2020). The suicide rate for Native Americans aged 15-19 is more than double that of their White counterparts (Blackmore et al., 2020). Without early intervention, children with mental and developmental challenges are more likely to engage in risky behaviors, including drug use, teenage pregnancy, and criminal activity (Amen, 2020). This underscores the World Health Organization's finding that depression is the leading cause of disability worldwide.

Additionally, Asian Americans are three times less likely than Whites to seek help for mental health challenges, illustrating a distinct cultural stigma surrounding mental illness (Blackmore et al., 2020). This stigma is reflected in the fact that only 8.6 percent of the Asian population seeks mental health services, which is significantly lower compared to White populations (Chaudhry & Chen, 2019). From 2017 to 2021, the fatherlessness rate among Asian Americans was 31 percent, compared to 76 percent among Black Americans, 39 percent among Whites, and 59 percent among Hispanics (Chaudhry & Chen, 2019).

Parental leadership plays a crucial role in the development of essential life skills. Tau (2020) asserts that children are more likely to develop critical developmental skills when a parent exercises consistent leadership. This study will explore the differences in mental health and behavioral outcomes between father-involved and father-absent households, with a focus on how paternal presence supports better coping mechanisms and relationship skills in children. While mental health issues affect all racial groups in the United States, significant disparities exist.

For instance, Black men who grow up without fathers are more than twice as likely to report psychological distress compared to those raised with paternal involvement (Tau, 2020). Turner (2019) found that depression symptoms are more severe, persistent, and resistant to treatment in Black and Hispanic males compared to their White counterparts. As Proverbs 23:22 states, "Listen to your father, who gave you life" (King James Version, 1789/2019), emphasizing the importance of paternal guidance. When a father is absent, the absence of counsel and voice leaves a significant gap in a child's development (Nazroo et al., 2019).

Purpose Statement

The purpose of this phenomenological study was to explore the lived experiences of fatherless children and understand how family environments influence mental health challenges, particularly across diverse racial groups.

During the 1980s, the lack of accessible resources left millions of children without adequate mental health awareness or support (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020). The application of Bowen's Family Systems Theory and Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory has provided researchers with valuable insights into how a child's social environment influences behavior.

These theories emphasize effective communication and positive behaviors as mechanisms for coping with mental health challenges, fostering acceptance and a sense of purpose. Specifically, Bowen's Family Systems Theory explores the interplay between mood and family engagement, examining how these factors affect mental health (Calatrava et al., 2022). Mental health interventions should focus on strengthening individuals' ability to identify positive habits and address negative ones (Agochukwu & Wittmann, 2019).

Research by Misra et al. (2021) underscores the variations in fatherlessness across different ethnic groups. For instance, Asian Americans have the lowest fatherlessness rate at 15 percent, followed by White Americans at 24.5 percent, Hispanic Americans at 31 percent, Native Americans at 41 percent, and African Americans at 66 percent (Fitzgerald et al., 2020). This qualitative study provided insights into why growing up without a father presents unique challenges for children compared to those raised with their biological parents.

The study explored how these obstacles impact children's success and overall well-being. Mental health challenges such as depression, ADHD, bipolar disorder, and suicide remain significant concerns today (DeLuca et al., 2021). Nazroo (2019) suggests that Black cultural attitudes toward mental health issues may diminish the likelihood of seeking effective mental health treatment. Thus, this study integrated various lived experiences to provide a deeper understanding of the causes, consequences, and implications of fatherlessness on mental health.

Significance of this Study

This phenomenological study highlighted the profound impact that challenging environments have on the mental and behavioral health of children growing up in fatherless households. Prior research has demonstrated a limited understanding of how societal factors affect the behavioral development of children (Calatrava et al., 2021). This study addresses this gap by connecting findings from fatherless families with organizational strategies aimed at addressing these challenges. According to the literature, the results of this study will provide valuable insights for families, mental health practitioners, and support groups, enhancing their understanding of how individuals from different racial and ethnic backgrounds experience mental health issues (Grau, Maestro, & Bowles, 2022).

Early diagnosis and intervention strategies will allow families to mitigate the negative effects of mental health challenges, leading to more fulfilling lives (Calatrava et al., 2021). By considering the ongoing global changes in psychological theory and practice, this research has the potential to alter perceptions of those suffering from mood disorders. As a result, fatherless children experiencing emotional and behavioral difficulties may benefit from an improved educational and therapeutic understanding (DeGarmo & Jones, 2019).

Research indicates that children from fatherless Asian American households exhibit a lower percentage of developmental challenges compared to their White, Black, and Hispanic counterparts (Trastek et al., 2019). In 2020, 51 percent of White males with mental illness were found to come from fatherless homes, compared to 27 percent of Asian children (Mensah et al., 2021). Approximately one in five adults is diagnosed with a mental illness each year (DeLuca et al., 2022). Ecological and family systems theories emphasize the importance of consistent, positive behavioral actions by fathers within the child's environment (DeGarmo & Jones, 2019).

These theories provide a framework for understanding how fathers can create a structured environment that fosters mental growth. The literature also illustrates how the adoption of both systems enhances the parent-child relationship, thereby promoting mental stability (Shim & Starks, 2021).

Research Questions

1. Does the absence of a father have an adverse effect on mental illness and child development?
2. Does the environment experienced by fatherless children contribute to mental illness?

A comprehensive understanding of fatherless families, developmental problems, and mental health challenges across racial and ethnic groups is essential to grasp the full scope of this phenomenological investigation. The primary goal of this study was to provide insight into the connection between fatherlessness and mental health disorders, offering clarity on the issues faced by individuals growing up in fatherless homes. To fully comprehend the research findings, familiarity with key terminologies is required.

Definition of Terms

1. Fatherless:

A family structure in which the father is absent, and the mother assumes both parental roles. The number of fatherless households has been rising since the 1980s (Duckworth, 2020). Various societal constraints and tribulations have contributed to the difficult decisions made by fathers, often leading to their absence (Iheanacho et al., 2021). Consequently, fatherless homes may exacerbate mental illness in children due to a lack of social connections, a negative environment, and financial hardships (Lange et al., 2021).

2. Mental Disorders:

Mood disorders are understood through family structure and ecological theories. According to the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5), there are over 300 types of mental disorders, each capable of causing moderate to severe episodes (Amen, 2020). Research shows that more than 50% of people will experience a mental disorder in their lifetime. Misdiagnosis is common, especially when symptoms vary across different racial groups (Iheanacho et al., 2021). Some cultures perceive mental illness as a sign of weakness, which discourages individuals from seeking professional help (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020). Early negative reactions due to inadequate resources often lead to long-term mental health consequences.

3. Mental Challenges:

Persistent periods of depression or emotional distress resulting from stress. Emotional and social distress are experienced differently depending on an individual's cultural values, often leading to low self-esteem and reduced self-efficacy (Moore et al., 2022).

4. Childhood Mental Disorders:

According to the DSM-5, two new childhood mental disorders include social communication disorder and disruptive mood dysregulation disorder (Barican, Yung, Schwartz, Zheng, Georgiades, & Waddell, 2021).

Summary

This phenomenological study explored the challenges faced by children growing up in fatherless homes. The qualitative analysis illustrated how fatherlessness in America has been driven by adverse consequences such as incarceration, divorce, and even death. Through the application of family systems and ecological therapies, strategies for overcoming these obstacles developed by using guided resources. By focusing on the core principles of listening, communication, and a commitment to growth, fathers can establish positive boundaries that help protect children from the mental health challenges that often arise in the absence of paternal involvement.

Strong leadership from a father creates a nurturing and stabilizing environment (DeGarmo & Jones, 2019). When a father passes down moral values to his family, his guidance helps children avoid harmful temptations, such as those related to sexual behavior and material greed (Uddin et al., 2020). Fathers must engage with systems theory frameworks, such as family and ecological systems theory, to foster trusting relationships that aid in coping with life's challenges. This knowledge can serve as the foundation for culturally appropriate interventions for minority populations, helping them effectively manage the unique barriers they face (Moore et al., 2022).

By doing so, individuals can transition from merely surviving their circumstances to thriving within them. The path to success often involves embracing failure as an opportunity for growth, particularly when facing life's challenges. A person without vision lacks direction, and without direction, progress is impossible (Thomas, 2022). These lessons are conveyed through daily father-child engagement. The root cause of many social disparities among younger generations is the absence of a father (Magqamfana & Bazana, 2020).

Fatherlessness often initiates a cycle of hardship, which includes issues like failure to make child support payments (DeLuca et al., 2021). These problems not only damage the father-child relationship but also contribute to broader negative perceptions of fatherhood in society (Blacksher & Valles, 2021). Such situations demonstrate how shirking responsibilities can become normalized. In alignment with Christian beliefs, it is essential to refrain from judging others who may seem different. Mental illness should be approached with patience, active listening, and effective communication (Bornstein, 2019). Prior research indicates that limitations in mental health therapy can significantly impact both mental wellness and childhood development (DeMartini et al., 2022).